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The Digitization Process of the Spatial Data on the Epigraphic Discoveries from the Central Archive L.2769 (Palace G, Ebla): A Comprehensive Overview*

Between September 30 and October 8, 1975, the Italian Archaeological Expedition to Syria (MAIS) unearthed the oldest known cuneiform archive found in situ. *In order to keep track of the whereabouts of all 15,000 inscribed objects within the Great Archive L.2769, archaeologists created a findspot registration system. Between 1975 and 1978, the team registered each item's location using this system, and inventoried all the epigraphic material. This paper offers an overview of the digitization process of the spatial data referring to epigraphic findings from L.2769 collected thus far as well as a comprehensive assessment of the findspot registration system.*

1. Introduction

The Italian Archaeological Expedition to Syria (MAIS, Sapienza University of Rome) spent nearly five decades exploring the ancient city of Ebla (modern Tell Mardikh).[1] One of its most remarkable discoveries took place between Septem-

* I would like to extend my gratitude to Paolo Matthiae and Frances Pinnock, Director and Co-director of the Italian Archaeological Expedition to Syria (MAIS), who warmly welcomed this project and offered me the opportunity to work on the expedition's archival materials and field notes. Further thanks are due to Lucio Milano, who originally conceived and then supported the project, assisting me during its most delicate stages. This research was funded by MIUR PRIN 2015, "Ebla e la Siria del Bronzo Antico: ricezione, circolazione e trasmissione di modelli culturali" (PI: Lucio Milano). During the research and writing period, which resulted in this publication, I benefited from the help of my colleagues and friends. I would like to thank Mohammed Alkhaled, Marta D'Andrea, and Davide Nadali (the vice-director of the expedition) who provided invaluable help in retrieving all the archival materials during my stay in Rome between October and November 2021. I also want to thank Amalia Catagnoti, who kindly agreed to give me an interview and share with me details on her work on the Ebla tablets. Special thanks are reserved for Francesco Di Filippo for discussing with me several aspects of the digitization process. I owe a special word of gratitude to Maria Gabriella Micale for her valuable suggestions during the project's earliest stages. This paper forms part of a larger study I am currently carrying out with Massimo Maiocchi (Ca' Foscari University of Venice) and Francesco Di Filippo (CNR – ISMed) within the *Ebla Digital Archives* project on tablets and fragments' distribution in L.2769. Portions of this study have already been presented at the 2022 EVOA conference (Sapienza University of Rome, June 31 – July 1, 2022; see Di Filippo *et al*. in press). All the errors and oversights in the paper are my own responsibility. Abbreviations: *A* = *ARET*, *Archivi Reali di Ebla, Testi*; *M* = *MEE*, *Materiali Epigrafici di Ebla*; MAT = Monthly Account of Textile; AAM = Annual Account of Metal. Inventory numbers are often abbreviated (TM.75.G.12345 = 75.12345).

1 The team directed by Paolo Matthiae and co-directed by Frances Pinnock excavated the tell